

**DEPARTMENT OF BUSINESS ADMINISTRATION
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LECTURE NOTES

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BY

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Perception and perceptual process

Perception is the process through which the information from the outside environment is selected, received, organized, and interpreted to make it meaningful to you. This input of meaningful information results in decisions and actions. According to Joseph Reitz, "Perception includes all those processes by which an individual receives information about his environment seeing, hearing, feeling, tasting and smelling. The study of these perpetual processes shows that their functioning is affected by three classes of variables objects or events being perceived, the environment in which perception occurs and the individual doing the perceiving. Similarly, Stephen P. Robbins defines perceptions as "A process by which individuals organize and interpret their sensory impressions to give meaning to their environment". In the same vein, Uday Pareek viewed "Perception as the process of receiving, selecting, organizing, interpreting and reaction to sensory stimuli or data".

Perception is dynamic because it involves ordering and attracting meaning to raw sensory data. Perception, therefore, is an information-processing activity. This information processing is fairly well understood and concerns the phenomena of selective attention and the perceptual organization of our senses sight, hearing, touch, taste, smell, and the senses of the internal body each consisting of the specialist nerves that respond to specific forms of energy such as pressure, sound, temperature changes, light, etc. Perception comprises three components: **The perceiver, The target (stimulus), and the situation.** The characteristics of each of these components influence the perceptual processes of selection, organization, and interpretation. The perceptual process is a sequence of steps that begins with the environment and leads to our perception of a stimulus and action response to the stimulus. The perception process consists of four steps

1. **Selection:** The first step in the perception process is **selection**. To build a foundation for selection, we must first attend to the senses. Our senses (sight, hearing, touch, taste, and smell) are bombarded with stimuli on any given day. Because we cannot respond to them all, we will choose what to pay attention to and when. This process is called **sensory selection**. In the process of attending to a stimulus rather

than paying attention to all the stimuli in your environment, you engage in selection, the process in which your mind and body help you choose certain stimuli to attend to. For example, you notice your classmate smiling at you without paying attention to what others in the classroom are saying or doing.

2. **Organizing** is the second part of the perception process, in which we sort and categorize information that we perceive based on innate and learned cognitive patterns. Three ways we sort things into patterns are by using **proximity**, **similarity**, and **difference** (COREN, 1980). Example Two people can look at the same image and interpret it differently.

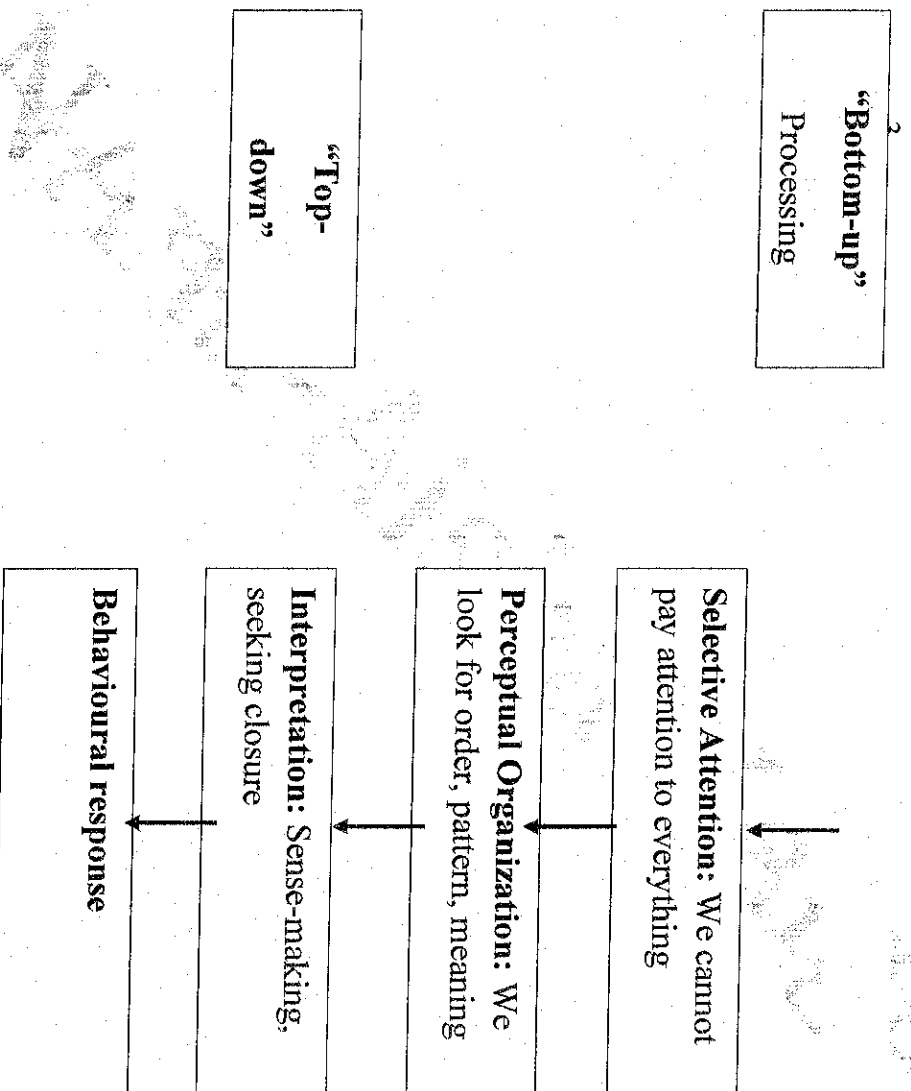


Figure 1: The process of perception

3. **Interpretation:** this is the third part of the perception process, in which we assign meaning to our experiences using mental structures known as schemata. Schemata are like databases of stored, related information that we use to interpret new experiences. In the **interpretation** stage, the mind will use all the

information from the previous steps to form an understanding of what the individual is sensing. In this step, necessary actions will also be decided from the mind. These judgments or meanings will be based on the above-mentioned rules, schemas, and scripts. Different people have different existing knowledge; therefore, they will also arrive at different conclusions from the same stimuli and thus carry out different actions for example, the class rep sees a black dog on the pavement (stimulation), he remembers that a dog of the same breed had chased him down the street before (organization). Now class rep decides that if he walks too close to the dog, he may get chased again, so he should stay away from the dog to make sure he is safe (interpretation).

4. Negotiation is the process by which communicators influence each other's perceptions through communication, and one way to explain negotiation is to view interpersonal communication as the exchange of stories or narratives that we tell to describe our world.

The incoming raw data from a psychological point of view, is the process of sensation on one hand and perception on the other working together through what are respectively termed "bottom-up" and top-processing "bottom down". The bottom-up phase concerns how we process the raw data received by our sensory apparatus. One of the key characteristics of bottom-up processing concerns the need for selectivity. We are simply not able to process all of the sensory information available to us at every given time. Bottom-up processing screens or filters redundant and non-relevant information so that we can focus on what is important, the "top-down" phase, in contrast, makes sense of our environment and our search for meaning. This distinction between sensation (bottom-up and perception (top-down) can be illustrated in our ability to make sense of incomplete or even incorrect sensory information. The missing letter or comma or the incorrectly spelled term does not normally interfere with the comprehension of the human reader. Our top-down conceptual processing ability means that we were able to fill in the gaps and correct mistakes and thus make sense of "imperfect" raw data. Our sensory apparatus has design limitations that filter or screen out some information such as X-rays.

Importance of Perception

- ✓ Perception is very important in understanding human behavior because every person perceives the world and approaches life problems differently, whatever we see or feel is not necessarily the same as it is. It is because what we hear is not what we see.
- ✓ perception is very important in understanding human behavior because every person perceives the world and approaches life problems differently, whatever we see or feel is not necessarily the same as it is. It is because what we hear is not what is said, but what we perceive as being said. Thus, it is because of perception, we can find out why one individual finds a job satisfying while another one may not be satisfied with it.
- ✓ Perception is very important for the manager who wants to avoid making errors when dealing with people and events in the work setting. This problem is made more complicated by the fact that different people perceive the same situation differently. To deal with subordinates effectively, managers must understand their perceptions properly.
- ✓ If people behave based on their perception, we can predict their behavior in the changed circumstances by understanding their present perception of the environment. One person may be viewing the facts in one way which may be different from the facts as seen by another viewer.
- ✓ With the help of perception, the needs of various people can be determined because their needs influence people's perceptions.
- ✓ With the help of perception, the needs of various people can be determined because their needs influence people's perceptions.
- ✓ It is vitally important if we want to get along with others to try to see things from their perspective or walk in their shoes for a while. If we walk in their shoes, we will gain a new perspective about things and, in that, understand the other and also can love and help the other more appropriately.

Categories of perception:

Perception is classified into internal and external. Internal perception (proprioception) tells us what is going on in our bodies; where our limbs are, whether we are sitting or standing, whether we are depressed, hungry, tired, and so forth. External or sensory perception (exteroception), tells us about the world outside our bodies.

Internal Factors Affecting Perception

- ✓ **Learning:** Our experience leads to the development of perceptual expectations or perceptual sets which gives us predispositions to perceive and pay attention to some stimuli and ignore other information
- ✓ Personality traits influence how a person selects perceptions. For instance, conscientious people tend to select details and external stimuli to a greater degree.
- ✓ Motivation - People will select perceptions according to what they need at the moment. They will favor selections that they think will help them with their current needs, and be more likely to ignore what is irrelevant to their needs. Etc

External factors influencing perception include the following:

1. **Size:** The size of the perceived stimulus plays a very vital role in attracting the perceiver towards it. The bigger the size of the stimulus, the higher the chances that it would attract the attention of the perceiver itself. Bigger objects dominate the view and hence, are more capable of attaining perceptual selection
2. **Intensity:** The degree of intensity is also crucial in perceptual selection i.e., the higher the intensity the higher the chances of perceptual selection. For example, a message will be more noticed if it is highlighted, underlined, and boldly displayed

3. **Frequency:** Repetition enhances the sensory alertness of a person. It means that if an external stimulus is repeated several times, it gets more attention than if displayed only once. Hence, a stimulus having a higher frequency of repetition has a greater chance of getting selected for attention.
4. **Status:** The status of the perceiver also influences the perception. Employees get more influenced by high-status people as compared to low-status people.
5. **Contrast:** Stimuli that mix with the environment are not as attractive as those that contrast with their surrounding environment. Factor differences from the rest of the surroundings cause a contrasting effect. This principle states that an external stimulus that stands apart from the crowd gets more attention.
6. **Characteristics of Situation:** The situation also influences perception to a great extent. For example, the time of viewing an object, the location, light, sound, heat or cold, or any kind of situational factor affects a person's perception. Etc

Managerial Implications of Perception

Perception is an important tool for managers. Proper knowledge of perception and its effective application empowers managers to make excellent decisions. Managerial Implications of Perception include the following:

- ✓ Motivation
- ✓ Hiring
- ✓ Performance Expectations
- ✓ Performance Appraisal
- ✓ Employee Effort
- ✓ Employee Loyalty
- ✓ Building Relationships
- ✓ Self-Assessment and Development

1) Motivation: Workplace perception is very important for motivation for example, if employees perceive that organizations are concerned about their development and growth, they become motivated for better performance. Therefore, organizations must promote their reception providing different opportunities for employees to learn new skills, perform challenging roles, etc.

2) Hiring: Perception affects hiring in several ways. A job application that displays a fresh perspective and is unique from others increases the chance that an applicant is selected. The human resource person might select applicants based on gender or race or maybe the halo effect might restrict him while perceiving an applicant. The interviewer's temperament at the time of the interview or his outlook toward the appearance of an applicant might also influence his perception. For example, a manager who prefers to see candidates formally dressed would certainly dislike a candidate who appears for the interview wearing goggles and a flowery shirt.

3) Performance Expectations: Perception helps managers in making a judgment regarding what to expect from an employee. If a manager intends to achieve high productivity from his employees, he should inform them about his expectations so that they can make efforts accordingly. Similarly, having a low-level perception would result in a lower level of productivity.

4) Performance Appraisal: In organizations, the managers evaluate the performance of their subordinates termed performance appraisal. This evaluation is both subjective as well as objective. Perception mainly plays its role when performance is evaluated on subjective criteria. The precision of the manager's perception of the employee's efforts plays an important role in his appraisal. This further affects employees' promotion and development. Hence, while evaluating, the manager should make sure that his perception is free from all biases.

5) Employee Effort: Many factors other than performance play a crucial role in deciding an individual's future in the company. Like, the manager's correct perception of the employee's effort may

help him move ahead. The analysis of effort is a subjective judgment and is prone to perceptual distortions and biases.

6) Employee Loyalty: Loyalty is expected from all employees working in an organization. Though employee loyalty is decreasing these days, still organizations appreciate it if employees, especially those working at managerial levels criticize the organization without any hesitation. Generally, it is seen that if it is known by the organization that an employee is looking for an opportunity somewhere else, then that particular employee is excluded from any promotional or developmental activities. The organization's drive towards attaining loyalty is a big issue and the assessment of an employee's loyalty towards his organization is a judgmental or perceptual process.

7) Building Relationships: If the manager's perception is positive or productive, it helps to build effective communication and trust among the employees and improve professional relationships between the manager, employees, and junior employees.

8) Self-Assessment and Development: Perception also helps in self-development. If what an individual perceives about himself is similar to others' perceptions about him, then he is gaining proficiency and competence and vice versa.

Review questions

1. Why do people use social perception?
2. Distinguish between the bottom-up processing of sensory information and the top-down interpretation of the information.
3. You observe someone behaving in what you perceive to be a highly unusual manner at work contrary as far as you can observe to common sense. How would you proceed to understand and make sense of their behavior?
4. Write short notes on the following:

- a) Performance Appraisal
- b) Employee Loyalty
- c) Performance Appraisal
- d) Motivation